livingschool

COMMUNITY CREATIVITY NATURE THINKING WELLNESS

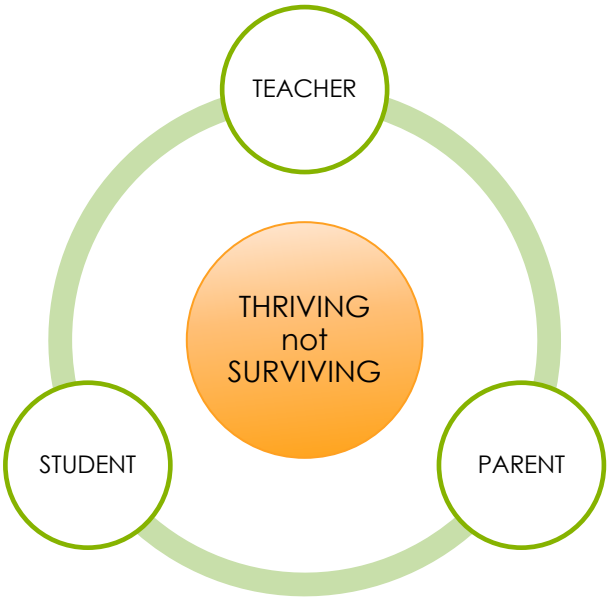
an independent co-learning community

LIVING SCHOOL PARENTS AS PARTNERS

VOLUNTEERING TO HELP AT LIVING SCHOOL

We have produced this booklet as a basic guide for those parents and helpers who are kind enough to volunteer to help our children in Living School. The whole staff values your contribution to our children's learning and appreciates your help. We hope you find your time with us rewarding, enjoyable and informative.

The Triangle of Learning Success



The central task of education is to implant a will and facility for learning; it should produce not learned but learning people. The truly human society is a learning society, where grandparents, parents, and children are students together.

Eric Hoffer

Living School Vision Statement:

Living School cares to teach, challenge and nurture good people for a sustainable future.

Our Values:

We believe in three values, which encompass many others:

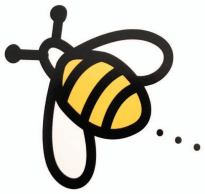
- Respect
- Responsibility
- Relationships that are positive and productive.

We believe that all children have a limitless potential and that the role of every educator and parent/carer is, before all else, to activate and mobilize the potential within a child, rather than see him or her from a point of view based on limitations and flaws.

Universal Qualities for Success



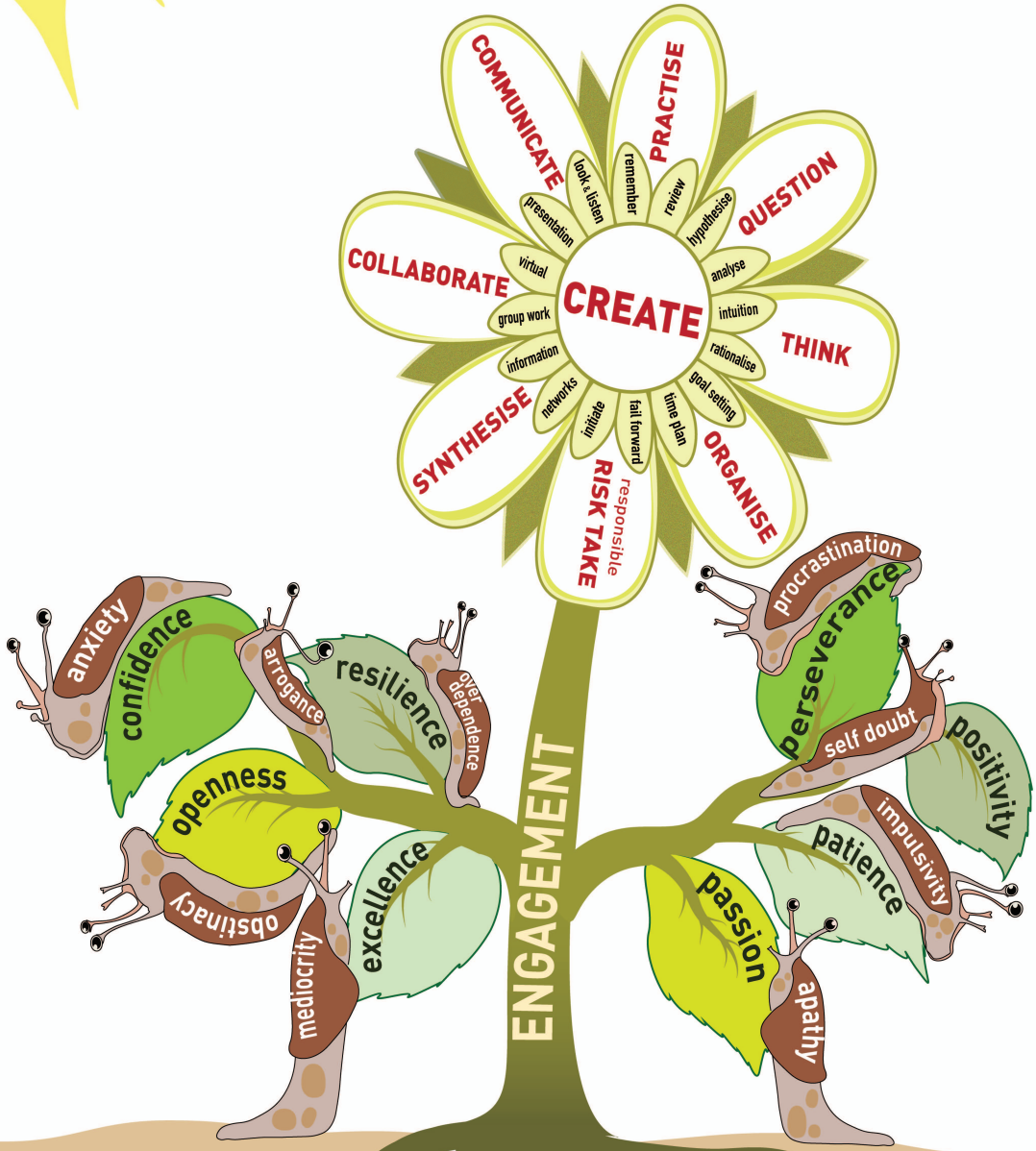
A Love of Learning and Kindness



Skills competencies

Attitudes capacities

Values ethics





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Behaviour Expectations

Living School's Parents as Partners four baseline *community behaviour standards:*

1. **Promotion of a *safe* environment where children and teachers are supported**
2. **Modelling *respect* for the rights and responsibilities of the school community, especially through positive communication processes**
3. **Active participation and engagement in schooling**
4. **Conscious and purposeful development of positive learning behaviours**

Practical implications:

School wisdoms and behaviour codes will be consistent with the concepts of safety, respect, effort and self-responsibility, and the actions of all school community members will uphold these expectations.

1. Safety

School community members will act in a lawful and responsible manner that presents no danger to the physical or emotional security of themselves or others.

Safety is exhibited in such conduct as:

- Appropriate use of equipment
- Following of school wisdoms and routines
- Moving safely through the school environment
- Resolution of conflict without violence
- Volunteers must never be alone with a child

2. Effort

School community members will be mindful of the fact that the primary aim of schooling is student learning. School members will actively fulfil their role in promoting this process to the best of their ability.

Effort is exhibited in such conduct as:

- Supporting teachers as guided, heeding the teacher's professional expertise
- Effective management of time and materials
- Contribution to life and activities of the school
- Cooperation in support plans

3. Respect

School community members will treat each other with courtesy, self-regulation and consideration at all times, being mindful of the rights and differing responsibilities of each person. Such courtesy will be reflected in both action and communication.

Respect is exhibited in such conduct as:

- Respecting the belongings of self and others
- Demonstrating an awareness of the rights, responsibilities and feelings of others
- Appropriate communication (including active listening)
- Following school expectations
- Maintaining positive relationships with other education stakeholders

4. Self-responsibility

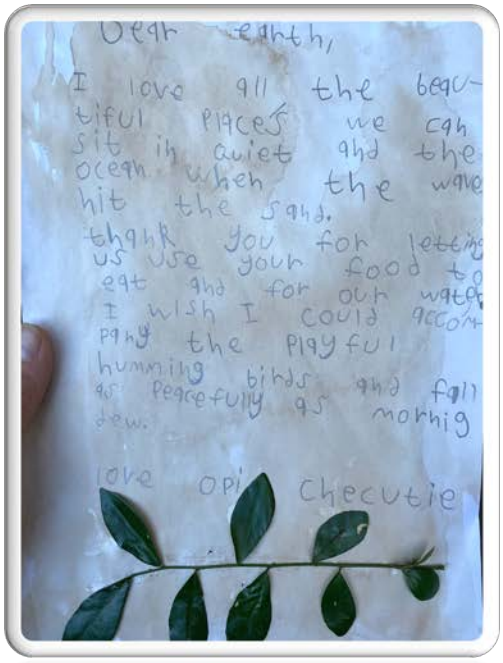
School community members will endeavour at all times to make appropriate behaviour choices relative to the social context, and to accept accountability for the outcomes of their actions.

Self-responsibility is exhibited in such conduct as:

- Following instructions of supervisors and/or teachers
- Making appropriate choices without supervision
- Accepting responsibility for one's own behaviour and emotional catalysts
- Having appropriate equipment for tasks with the time to orchestrate requirements

What is the Aim of Parents as Partners?

- Nurture a community of support
- Utilise our people-power to benefit our students' learning
- Build networks: parent/teacher; parent/parent; parent/student
- Support our teachers
- Learn
- Have fun!



What is NOT our aim?

- Label children, classes and teachers
- Compare our children with others
- Promote rivalry and competition
- Spy on the "hidden world of the classroom"
- Break down our trust
- Train parents to be teachers – teaching is a profession

Benefits to Parents

- Improve school/home communication
- Increase your comfort level in the school buildings
- Improve student self-esteem
- Learn new skills and using them to benefit the school
- Understand your child's education
- See your child in action
- Discover new aspects of your child
- Network with other parents
- Provide a non-threatening, anxiety- and confrontation-free way to visit the school

Know Thyself

What are your interests, abilities, and skills? Do you prefer working independently or following a set path?

How do you really feel about a room full of kids? Would you rather work at home? What's your schedule? You might not adore every task, but it shouldn't drive you crazy either. Discuss your preferences and talents with the teacher to find an appropriate role.

The Classroom

Be aware that the classroom is the teacher's domain. Wait to be introduced by the teacher. Let the teacher set the tone. You are there to establish a good positive relationship with the students and the teacher.

First - Sign in at the Front Desk

It is very important that we know exactly who is on the school premises and where they are. We therefore ask that every adult who comes into the school does so via the main gate. Helpers must first report to the Office. They will then be given a badge and asked to sign the parent helpers' book.

We ask that parents do not enter the learning environment unless the teacher is present.

Supervising Children

Whenever you are supervising children, the following points will be of help:

1. **Always treat children with respect** and in the same sort of way that you would expect them to treat you.
2. **Be friendly** towards them.
3. **Volunteers must never be alone with a child**
4. **Avoid shouting**. If you speak normally they will have to be quiet in order to hear what you are saying.
5. Tell them exactly what to do in as much detail as possible.
6. **Don't be afraid to quietly and calmly correct a child**, but never manhandle the children at any time. If in doubt, speak to the nearest member of staff. There are very strict procedures we must follow.

You must never use physical force. Living School has a clear discipline policy that states we do not use nor condone any corporal punishment.

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6. **Praise the children wherever possible** for effort. You are able to notify a teacher if you feel a child deserves special mention.

7. Do not let the children become 'silly' or over-friendly with you. They must learn to behave socially towards adults who are not close friends. **Encourage them to be polite to one another**.

8. If you are concerned about a child for any reason, have a word with the class teacher or the Conductor - **Do not speak directly to the parents of the child**. This is the teacher's job (see section on confidentiality)

9. **Commit to your time allocation**. Teachers prepare for you and so if you commit to a day a week for a term, you must stick to that time allocation. Do not offer more than you can commit!

10. If you are ill, please inform the Office as soon as possible – **do not come to a lesson if you are ill**.

Hearing Readers

One of the tasks that you will probably be involved in is reading with the children. This is an important but time consuming task. The exact approach will depend on the reading level of the child.

Beginning readers

- Children should be aware that you read from left to right, turning the pages that way and reading the lines left to right and top to bottom.
- Read the book together to start with.
- Discuss the pictures and the story.
- Read the book again pointing to each word as you read.

Early readers

- Ask the child to point to each word as s/he reads it.
- Discuss the pictures and the story.
- Read the story together.
- Ask the child to find key words which are repeated several times in the book i.e.. 'the',' up',' in', etc.
- The children should be aware of full stops and that you need to pause at a full stop and not to run sentences together.

Extending reading

As the children develop to read more words try to get them to work out new words by making a good logical guess. Maybe the picture will help. If the child has good knowledge of initial sounds, looking at the first letter strings or small words within words, sound out the whole word, e.g. *ing* in k*ing*.

Try to get the child to read to the end of the sentence and then go back to work out an unknown word. Even with competent readers **you should discuss the stories and pictures**. Also you can try to encourage the children to use expression or put on suitable voices.

Have the child predict what will happen – predicting is a key for comprehending text and inferring meaning.

Discussion Questions

The following are examples of the types of questions to use when discussing a story.

- What was the story about? (Reflective Question)
- Who was the main character? (Recall Question)
- What sort of a person was he? (Interpretative Question)
- Was that a sensible thing to do? (Inferential Question)
- What should he have done? (Predictive Question)
- Which part did you like best? (Interpretative Question)
- What would have happened if….? (Predictive Question)

Try to relate some ideas to the children's own experiences. i.e.

- Can you….?
- Have you ever?

Acknowledge, Encourage and Praise

Show you appreciate children's **efforts** in meeting your expectations by praising and thanking them. Your approval is a great encouragement for kids – highlight positive behaviour rather than point to negative displays.

We do not use treats as incentives.

Carol Dweck is well-known for her work on developing **Growth Mindsets** in learners. She emphasizes we should praise authentically on effort – not attainment.

Statements of Praise

The following are statements you can use to help encourage your child while he/she is reading.

- I like the way you tried to help yourself.
- Good for you! I saw you checking the word with the picture to see if you were right.
- I like the way you worked out the hard part.
- I noticed you tried _____ when you had trouble. Good for you. That's what good readers do.
- I noticed you paused before you read right here (point). After you paused, you read the word correctly. Great effort!
- I'm so proud of your efforts and skills.
- I love the way you read this sentence with feeling.
- You are reading with lots of expression. I'm really proud of your commitment.
- I like the way you were ready and said the first sound.

Confidential Information

Occasionally in school you will become aware of information about children which is confidential or private to the child or their family. This is a delicate matter that requires a great deal of tact on your part. Any information that leads you to believe a child is at risk should be mentioned to the head teacher. But any conversation with parents outside is a breach of the school's confidence. Even a comment such as, 'Your Jimmy reads well,' is not acceptable as others will wonder why you have not said that to them.

It is very important to treat anything you hear or see in school with regard to particular children as being in absolute confidence and entirely a matter within the school.

Similarly, you may find that parents who are friends will ask about the progression or behaviour of their children in school. Again, this is a matter requiring a great deal of tact on your part and it is very important that you firmly suggest that if they are worried in any way about their child then they must discuss the matter themselves with the class teacher.

How parents and carers can help

Parents and carers scaffold children's learning by leading and coaching them towards coming up with their own answers. This shows children how to learn, and makes it more likely that they will succeed. The next time your child asks for help, you might try some of the following ways to scaffold thinking and learning.

- **Prompt children to extend their thinking**
  - Ask them to think about something relevant: *"Why do you think…?"*
  - Ask them to think through alternatives: *"That would be one way, what's another way we could try?"*
  - Provide support for thinking through difficult tasks: *"Let's have a think about this together."*
- **Ask them to explain the steps**
  - Help children to plan their approach: *"What is it that we need to do?"*
  - Ask them to review their steps so far: *"Tell me more about what you have already tried?"*
- **Demonstrate**
  - Show an example and talk it through: *"First, I will …, and then I will …, and then I can… "*
- **Break it into steps**
  - Help children who are stuck by breaking the task into smaller steps.
  - It's a good idea to ensure the first step involves something that children can already do. This way they will experience success early which helps their confidence.
  - Be sure to provide praise for completing each step as they work through a task.
  - Guide children step-by-step to build their skills so they can eventually complete the whole task on their own.

Tips for scaffolding children's learning:

- Provide a challenge that is *just* beyond what your child can already do easily by **themself.**
- Give prompts.
- Ask questions.
- Model the steps involved.
- Praise your child for attempting the task, not just for succeeding.
- Watch to see if your child is struggling or becoming frustrated, as these may be signs that the task is too hard.





TOP TIPS – Volunteering in the Living School

A non-teacher would never guess the stress that teachers go through in preparing and organizing tasks for volunteers to complete. Today's teachers are busy dealing with discipline issues, assessments, constantly developing curricula, and student safety. Many stay after school until well past dinner trying to stay on top of the game. A collective groan can surge through the teachers' staffroom as we realize parent volunteers are coming and we still haven't found the time to organize tasks for them.

The stressors that make it difficult for teachers to organize work for their volunteers are also the very same reasons we so desperately need assistance in our classrooms. We need volunteers to help shape our children into individuals with strong spirits who respect the collective.

The classroom teacher will strive to make the best use of volunteers by assigning them important and meaningful work. But it's always a struggle to find the time to organize projects for a volunteer or even to explain how the classroom works. The following is a system that sets up the volunteers for success throughout the year, no matter how busy we get.

1. First Meeting

Schedule a 20-minute conference with your cooperating teacher to cover your daily responsibilities, the classroom behaviour plan, individual needs of students, and school-wide safety procedures. Bring a list of specific questions and concerns to make the most of your scheduled time. Don't forget to ask about procedures for fire drills, school lockdowns, and other emergency situations.

2. Teachers' Staffroom

The old house (my old home) is for teachers only. A classroom teacher should not ask you to enter the old house, even if it is to collect something he/she has forgotten. Please remind a busy teacher that you are not allowed to enter the house.

3. Organisation – getting the students ready

Teachers often need the most help with readying students for their next lesson/activity. Take an initiative – without encroaching on the teacher's control – by asking which children require organisational support. Help them tidy their desks/property and get out the equipment they require.

4. Be Open-minded

Try not to judge the teacher's teaching methods and discipline strategies, especially during your first few volunteer sessions. It may appear as if the teacher has a diverse range of expectations for individual students regarding discipline and academics. But keep in mind that the teacher knows confidential details concerning the students' academic abilities, domestic situations, and medical information that may affect behaviour and interaction.

5. Boundaries

Before you start your volunteer experience, have a clear idea of what your personal boundaries are. **Our students are expected to show respect** but they will call you by your first name. Are you willing to discuss aspects of your personal life, such as your spouse and children?

Children ask adults a lot of personal questions in an attempt to bond. Because children are developing social skills, they are still learning the difference between appropriate and inappropriate questions. Answer personal questions that are within your comfort level as long as they are asked during suitable times. If a child asks a question that you don't want to answer, let him know in a polite way.

6. Communication

It may be difficult to find time during a busy school day to actually talk with the teacher, so if you have any questions or concerns, let the teacher know that you need to set up a time to talk. You might want to ask your cooperating teacher for her/his e-mail address in case you need to contact her/him between your scheduled volunteer days.

Always let the teacher know if you are having difficulty with a task. Completing a project the wrong way creates more work for the teacher than taking a few minutes to ask questions during the process.

7. Behaviour Plan

Living School has a positive behaviour plan and teachers establish consequences for negative behaviour, as well as highlighting positive behaviour. Many teachers add to the school wide guidelines by making a more specific behaviour plan for their classroom. Know the method that your cooperating teacher uses to handle positive and negative learning behaviour, and know what role you will play in that plan. Try to follow the behaviour plan as closely as possible to the way the teacher does. This will prevent a good cop, bad cop scenario. Remember, you are not the class disciplinarian.

8. Assessment

Ask the teacher to explain his/her system for mapping a child's progress, and the part s/he would like you to take in the process. Does s/he want you to help collect activities or support class learning activities? In order to keep each learning group's assessment process consistent and confidential, no school volunteer is to 'mark' any student work.

9. Special Needs Students/ELL Students

Every class has individual students who need more help than the teacher can provide on any given day. These students may have behaviour problems, learning disabilities, or personality traits that cause them to need extra attention from an adult. Ask your cooperating teacher which students you can help.

Often it is most useful to help needy students during transition times or getting unpacked and organized at the start and end of lessons. You'll be surprised at the positive difference you can make in a child's life by extending just a few minutes of your individual attention.

And remember, volunteering in the classroom is one of the most important things you can do to help build a strong community. A child's values, goals, and personality are shaped by the people who come into his or her life, if only for a brief moment.

In case we teachers forget to say so, please be assured that we really do appreciate your help (we may be too busy to say so but we do!!)

If you have any worries or queries, or any good ideas on how we can improve something, please let us know - We are always willing to listen.

Once again...

Thank You!

"I have come to a frightening conclusion. I am the decisive element in the classroom. It is my personal approach that creates the climate. It is my daily mood that makes the weather. As a teacher I possess tremendous power to make a child's life miserable or joyous. I can be a tool of torture or an instrument of inspiration. I can humiliate or humour, hurt or heal. In all situations, it is my response that decides whether a crisis will be escalated or de-escalated, and a child humanized or de-humanized." - Haim Ginott



